

Vietnamization

Wary of the rising human costs and the unpopularity of the war in Vietnam, the Nixon administration was eager to withdraw American troops. As the US increased economic aid to South Vietnam, it also made moves to transfer the burden of fighting to the ARVN.

◀◀ BEFORE

The escalation of the number of US ground forces in Vietnam peaked in the spring of 1969.

REEVALUATING COMMITMENT

US military personnel in Vietnam totaled 543,000 in April 1969, marking the highpoint of American ground combat forces and support personnel. ARVN strength was at 897,000. Since the first **build-up of US forces** in 1965, US infantry and airmobile divisions had conducted large-scale offensive operations, while ARVN troops had provided **population security** and conducted smaller operations. However, the 1968 **Tet Offensive** had prompted the Johnson administration to reexamine its strategy in Vietnam. By 1969, public opinion and that in Washington had shifted against the war.

By 1969, the war had gone on longer and cost more than anyone had foreseen. General Creighton Abrams had replaced Westmoreland as the head of Military Assistance Command Vietnam (MACV) in 1968, and after Nixon became president, Abrams began a process called Vietnamization.

The Nixon Doctrine

Reportedly coined by Nixon's Secretary of Defense Melvin Laird, Vietnamization was the operational term for what journalists called the Nixon Doctrine. It was the policy of transferring responsibility for combat in Vietnam from American forces to the ARVN, leading to the withdrawal of US troops from Vietnamese soil.

Citing improved ARVN capability, the White House announced the withdrawal of 25,000 US forces on June 8, 1969. Shortly after, Nixon met with South Vietnamese president Nguyen Van Thieu at Midway Island. He praised Thieu's leadership and reaffirmed US support for the Saigon government. Then, in a press conference on the Pacific island of Guam, in July 1969, the US president made a statement—quickly labeled the Nixon Doctrine—that while the US would continue to provide military and economic aid to its allies, those nations would henceforth be expected to use their own soldiers to bear the burden of any fighting.

Although Vietnamization was portrayed as evidence of progress in Saigon, it was actually central to Nixon's effort to end the drain of the war on the United States and reduce political pressure at home. Its timing and evolution were determined almost entirely by US domestic politics. Fewer American service personnel in Vietnam meant fewer American casualties—and, the administration hoped, less public outcry against the war. While the program decreased the role of American troops, it also increased supplies to the ARVN, reassuring the war's supporters that commitment to South Vietnam remained strong.

To be successful, Vietnamization had to be about more than simply substituting ARVN troops for US units—or South Vietnamese blood for American blood. Efforts to strengthen Saigon's military forces were straightforward. As US troop levels dropped sharply in 1969 and 1970, MACV returned to the advisory model for US units that had existed before 1965. MACV set up special schools and training activities in a "modernization and improvement program" for the expanded ARVN.